

Profile **A.R. RAHMAN**

Golden Globe for his score in *Slumdog Millionaire*. Rahman's world is as multicultural as it is multiplying. A state-of-the-art commercial studio started in 2005 forms the hub, a music conservatory with 40 full-time foundation students and 50 preparatory students begun last year, is the realisation of a long-cherished dream. A newly launched music label allows him to give a platform to new talent. And his own work, usually composed at night while the world sleeps, in his private studio at his Kodambakkam home in Chennai, reaches newer heights. What makes him the finest among our musicians (who can go from a Meera bhajan to a Sufi *Khwaja mere khwaja* in *Jodhaa Akbar*) also distinguishes him as an Indian. A devout Muslim, his first public performance was in a church on the keyboard for his teacher, and for many, his best works remain the stirring rendition of *Vande Mataram*, the flag swaying in the wind in tandem with his hair.

How does he do it? If Rahman is a true believer, who insists that every lyric should be like a prayer, so are those who work with him. Only their faith is in him. Most of them have been with him for over a decade, having known him much before Mani Ratnam's *Roja* propelled him to national fame. Noell James, former singer of many Rahman jingles, has worked with him for 22 years and been his manager ever since he can remember. T. Selvakumar, a former keyboard player who would source his instruments for him, is now the CEO of the KM Music Conservatory. Vijay Mohan Iyer, a friend for 14 years, now runs his music label. Deepak Gattani, introduced to him by singer Hariharan 16 years ago, handles his concert and endorsements. Liz Cook, formerly with the US Government, takes care of his film work. And yes, two recent acquisitions, the law firm of Collins Long and the agents Sam Schwartz, take care of the global brand he is becoming. "It's not about me. It's about how as a team we survive and excel. That's when you can do good things," Rahman says.

At the centre of this vortex, the star remains calm, trying to meet deadlines, juggling the media's sudden interest in him, and yes, trying to pray five times a day. It clears his mind, allowing the purity of music to filter in. And what music. As Rahman has evolved, so has his amazing ability to synthesise sounds, taking Carnatic, Western classical, Sufi, Indian classical, jazz and pop and then putting it all together like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle at his Fantome keyboard while the sound engineers burn up the Neve 88R console. Not for him the rigidity of other music directors who are sticklers for their tune. His working style is more collaborative, allowing the musicians to jam together and interpret a piece of music the way they want to. It explains the layers and subtext to his songs. It's a process that can take hours, and the comfortable

Things you didn't know ABOUT RAHMAN

■ He sleeps from 9 a.m. to 3 p.m., starting work only at 6 p.m. every day.

■ His mother could afford to send him to guitar lessons only after his elder sister Raihanah had to drop out. "I didn't mind," she says.

■ His first public performance was at the age of 11 in a church where his master Jacob John had taken him.

■ He changed his name to Allah Rakha Rahman on



the credits of the soundtrack of *Roja* in 1992.

■ His first stop in any new city is either an electronic store where he likes to buy the latest equipment or a mosque.

